ESP LEADERSHIP TEAM MEETING

What we demand of AI.

October 20, 2026

A distinct role for Economic Security Project

Working proposal for discussion

At the retreat, someone asked: “Why is there no positive vision for AI?”

It can become a brief for the companies.

Making the case for AI can put us on the companies’ side, without the critical distance to set our own terms.

It assumes what we need to prove.

We still have to show where AI belongs in a better world, rather than assume that it does.

It leaves power unresolved.

A desirable use does not show that its benefits can be realized under concentrated ownership and control.

It can undershoot the stakes.

Useful examples like benefits delivery do not, by themselves, answer the scale of change people fear or hope for.

There is a major gap here for ESP: what must AI deliver, and what would have to change to get there?

Find a distinct way for ESP to show up in a crowded AI policy world.

Our contribution has to be recognizable, credible, and worth organizing around.

What can we bring that draws on our strengths and changes what people demand?

A clear purpose can hold very different approaches together.

01

A clear case

The fully refundable Child Tax Credit and reducing childhood poverty.

02

A grounded provocation

Natalie Foster's *The Guarantee*: a concrete account of what people should be able to count on.

03

A common umbrella

Guaranteed Income Community of Practice: room for divergent approaches toward a shared purpose.

The lesson for AI: be clear about the destination; make room to contest the route.

We are economic security experts. The target is still moving.

We don't know the extent of the technology.

How capable it becomes, how quickly it spreads, or how work reorganizes around it.

We don't know the extent of the economic harms.

The scale, timing, and distribution of displacement and lost bargaining power remain uncertain.

It is hard to hit a target that may not exist in the form we imagine.

Existing harms warrant action now. Uncertainty about scale is not a reason to wait.

Cash is a difficult starting point in the polling we've seen.

Our best-known tool may not be the strongest opening argument for AI.

Start with the security people should be able to count on. Then argue for the tools that deliver it.

Team assessment; polling evidence to be inserted.

POLLING IMAGE

Reserved for your chart

Add the question wording, population, field dates, and source.

How are others showing up?

EMPHASIS	STARTING QUESTION	ILLUSTRATION
Aggressive on regulatory structure	What rules and institutions should govern AI?	VPA Vanderbilt Policy Accelerator
Aggressive on technological harms	Which uses and risks should we limit or stop?	A cross-cutting approach Safety, surveillance, discrimination
Aggressive on existing authority	What can public officials enforce now?	AELP American Economic Liberties Project; antitrust

None of these, on its own, particularly plays to ESP's strengths.

A qualitative map of emphases, not exclusive organizational categories.

Give people something concrete to demand.

01

A standard AI must meet

Name what people should gain, without deferring to the companies' account of progress.

02

AI in our lives

Work, care, expertise, time, and security: between a narrow issue like children's safety and an abstraction like democracy.

03

Economics that meets the technology

Push the discipline toward what is changing, then connect the provocation to a decision someone can act on.

What We Demand of AI

More capability. Better working lives.
Security and freedom through change.

Technology | Work | Economic security

A common umbrella for research, provocation, and action.

Expand what people can do. Limit what can be done to them.

Access to expertise should widen. Power to surveil, manipulate, and impose risks should face enforceable limits.

Make the demand concrete

Public capacity and procurement should test useful tools against simpler software, more staff, and other alternatives.

Show what would count

More people can solve a real problem, on reliable and affordable terms, with authority to challenge harmful uses.

A reason to build useful capabilities and a standard for refusing harmful ones.

An hour saved should improve a working life.

Workers should have the power to turn productive gains into better pay, more time, and greater autonomy.

Make the demand concrete

Bargain over deployment and the use of gains before the new workflow becomes fixed.

Show what would count

Track pay, actual hours, intensity, discretion, learning, and service quality together.

A faster task has not yet told us who benefits.

No one should have to prove AI took their job to deserve security.

Guarantee the essentials through change. Give everyone a claim on greater prosperity.

Make the demand concrete

Dependable income protection, healthcare, and essential services, with public claims on gains where they materialize.

Show what would count

People can leave bad work, provide care, and learn without losing the essentials, including outside paid employment.

Build a guarantee that holds even if the AI boom disappoints.

“What do we demand of AI?” is an open question.

It gives people a way to name both what they want protected and what they want to change.

What we refuse

“We demand that AI companies do not deplete our communities’ water and natural resources.”

What we want to make possible

“We demand that AI makes work easier and lets people work fewer hours without a pay cut.”

We can poll what people demand of AI. It is also a provocative question for our creators to ask, opening stories, conversations, and campaigns.

Can this be our common umbrella?

Invite people to answer the question. Develop one case through all three demands.

1

What becomes possible?

A useful capability with clear limits.

2

Who gets to decide?

Workers and the public shape its use.

3

Who gains security?

The benefits reach beyond owners and jobs.

Build a shared question for communications, and concrete demands we can organize around.